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Outdoor Hospitality Trends 2026: ten shifts for operators who sell seats outside

Ten sourced 2026 trends for restaurant, bar and hotel terraces: guest demand, soft traffic, energy costs, permanent outdoor dining and the move off propane.



EDITION
October 2026

BROMIC HEATING
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Outdoor seats are no longer a summer bonus. In 2026 they are part of how a restaurant, bar or hotel protects traffic, earns on space it already pays for, and meets rules that are moving fuel off the terrace. The ten shifts below are written for operators and the architects who design for them: each states the finding, gives its source, and ends with one move you can make this season.



Rooftop lounge with Eclipse freestanding heaters at sunset

At a glance



#	THE SHIFT	THE NUMBER	SOURCE
01	The patio is a revenue line	35% of operators with outdoor dining said it was over 40% of daily sales	NRA, 2021[1]
02	Guests choose the outside table	55% of Americans prefer to dine outdoors in good weather	OpenTable, 2025[3]
03	Soft traffic makes every seat count	61% of full-service operators saw lower traffic in 2025	NRA, 2026[2]
04	Energy is a line operators now watch	82% of full-service operators call energy or utility costs a significant challenge	NRA, 2026[2]
05	Outdoor dining is permanent infrastructure	Nearly 2,450 setups in Dining Out NYC	NYC, 2025[5]
06	Propane is leaving the patio	NYC revoked propane heaters in outdoor dining from June 2021	NYC EEO 200[7]
07	Electrification reaches the terrace	New NYC buildings: no fuel at or above 25 kg CO2 per million Btu	NYC DOB[10]
08	Guests come for the occasion	84% say a meal out is a chance to socialize	NRA, 2026[2]
09	Hotels make outdoor space earn	GOPPAR still about 90% of 2019	AHLA, 2026[12]
10	Heat disappears into the architecture	30% open perimeter defines an outdoor space	Bromic, 2021[14]

01 · The patio is a revenue line, not an amenity



> ***35%** of operators with outdoor dining said it made up more than 40% of average daily sales; 41% among full-service.[1] Source: National Restaurant Association, operator survey, September 2021.*

> ***93%** of full-service and **73%** of limited-service operators said on-premises was the more successful part of their business in 2025.[2] Source: National Restaurant Association, State of the Restaurant Industry 2026.*

What it means for an operator

- The terrace is capacity you already lease. Unheated, it is idle for months.
- On-premises is where operators say they win; the patio is on-premises.
- Budget for it like the dining room, not like furniture.

Bromic insight. A heated seat is a seat you can sell on a night it would otherwise sit empty. Count it in covers, not in heaters.

Design move. Put the terrace in the revenue model before the fit-out: seats × turns × average check × extra nights. The ROI article shows the method.

Bromic project. Kahite Golf Course Pub & Grill, Tennessee: a club built a covered, curtained patio around Tungsten Electric heaters chosen for a low ceiling, to add outdoor seating to its grill.

02 · Guests choose the outside table, and stay longer at it



> *__55%__ of Americans prefer to sit outdoors when the weather is nice; __34%__ would rather brave unexpected weather than give up an outdoor table.[3] Source: OpenTable, consumer survey by Walr, 2,000 US adults, April 2025.*

> *In Canada, outdoor diners averaged __127 minutes__ at the table, __20%__ longer than the overall average, and outdoor dining rose __24%__ year over year.[4] Source: OpenTable diner data, March 2025 – February 2026.*

What it means for an operator

- Demand for the outside table is strong; comfort is what limits it.
- Longer stays mean more drinks and desserts, and fewer turns.
- A guest who gets cold leaves early and books inside next time.

Bromic insight. Guests do not ask for heaters. They ask for the table outside, and stay if they are warm.

Design move. Heat the seat, not the space: place radiant heat over each table group so every chair is in the field.

Bromic project. Hotel Skansen, Sweden: Eclipse Smart-Heat Freestanding heaters with the Eclipse Dimmer Controller keep the SAND restaurant terrace in use.

03 · Soft traffic makes every seat count

> ***61%** of full-service and **64%** of limited-service operators said customer traffic was lower in 2025 than in 2024.[2] Source: National Restaurant Association, State of the Restaurant Industry 2026.*

> ***85%** of full-service and **65%** of limited-service operators say building on-premises business will matter more to their success in 2026.[2] Source: as above.*

What it means for an operator

- With fewer visits, the room you offer has to be one guests choose.
- A terrace that works in October is a reason to come in.
- Seats that close in autumn are capacity lost when it is hardest to replace.

Bromic insight. In a soft year, the cheapest seat to add is the one you already have outside.

Design move. Plan for the shoulder months first: a partial cover plus radiant heat creates a heat cloud that adds a convective boost.[14]



Guests dining on a heated restaurant terrace

04 · Energy is now a line operators watch



> ***82%** of full-service and **79%** of limited-service operators called energy or utility costs a significant challenge in 2025; **42%** of operators said they were not profitable.[2] Source: National Restaurant Association, State of the Restaurant Industry 2026.*

> *US commercial electricity averaged **14.07 cents per kWh**, January–May 2026.[13] Source: U.S. Energy Information Administration, Monthly Energy Review.*

What it means for an operator

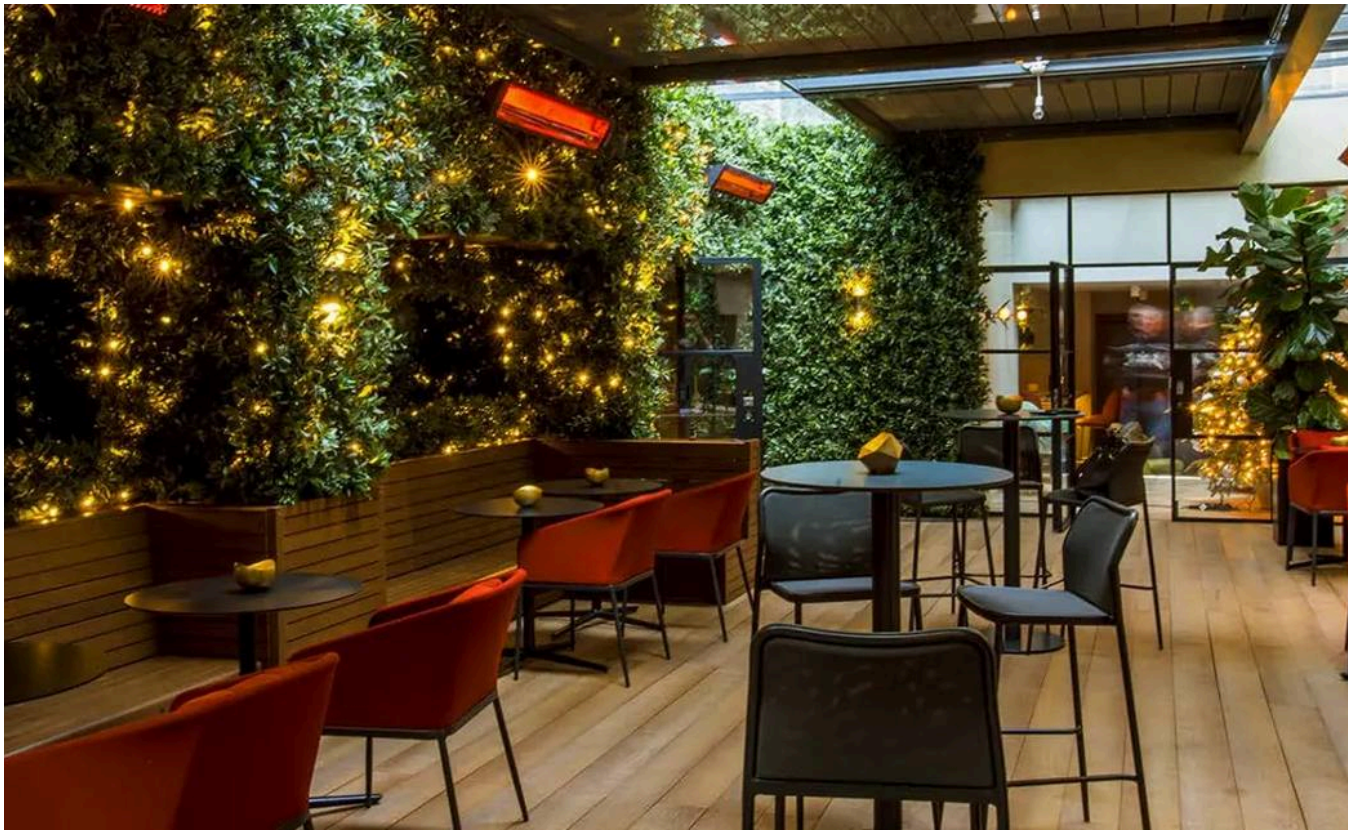
- Heat that runs all night on an empty terrace is margin lost.
- Outdoor heat cannot be held by a thermostat, so control is the lever.[14]
- Running cost is a formula you can show: kW × $/kWh.

Bromic insight. The heater sets what is possible; the controls set what it costs. Every Bromic recommendation includes them: Affinity Smart-Heat On/Off or Dimmer controller, or the Eclipse controller, a wall switch and the Bromic Smart-Heat app.

Design move. Zone heat to sections and servers, schedule it to the reservation book, and use output steps (Eclipse runs at 33, 66 or 100%).[15] App zones, schedules and timers need compatible Affinity Smart-Heat Controls, sold separately. For a five-year cost by fuel, see the TCO comparison.

Bromic project. Del Frisco's, Westfield Century City, Los Angeles: Platinum Electric heaters on a wireless controller and dimmer for year-round patio dining.

05 · Outdoor dining is now permanent infrastructure



> *NYC's permanent programme, Dining Out NYC, had nearly **2,450** roadway and sidewalk setups in 2025, more than two and a half times the pre-COVID sidewalk cafe programme. Sidewalk setups may run year-round; roadway setups from 1 April to 29 November.[5] Source: City of New York, Office of the Mayor, 1 April 2025.*

> *England made pavement licences permanent from 31 March 2024, for up to two years, with heaters named among permitted furniture.[6] Source: UK Government, Pavement licences: guidance, 2024.*

What it means for an operator

- Outdoor seating is licensed, inspected and renewed: an asset, not a pop-up.
- Seasons are set by rule; the months you are allowed matter more than the weather.

- Equipment has to meet the code that applies to it, every renewal.

Bromic insight. Permanent programmes reward permanent thinking: fixed, listed electric heat on the structure, with controls, outlasts a row of portable cylinders.

Design move. Design to the licence: where only removable furniture is allowed, specify freestanding electric; where a structure is permitted, mount heat on it. NYC requires outdoor electric radiant heaters to meet the NYC Electrical Code.[9]

Rules vary by city and change often. Confirm what applies with your local authority having jurisdiction, and use a licensed electrician or gas fitter.

06 · Propane is leaving the patio



> *New York City revoked permission to use propane-fuelled heaters in outdoor dining areas from **1 June 2021**.[7] Source: City of New York, Emergency Executive Order No. 200.*

> *Under the International Fire Code as adopted locally, portable outdoor gas heaters may not sit beneath or within **5 ft** of combustible overhangs and awnings, or within 5 ft of exits.[8] Source: City of Gresham, Oregon, IFC 605.5.2.1.3–605.5.2.1.4.*

What it means for an operator

- Cylinders bring storage, exchange labour and inspection questions.
- Clearances rule portable gas out of many covered or tight terraces.
- The cheapest heater to buy can be the hardest to keep legal.

Bromic insight. Electric radiant heat removes fuel handling from service and can be mounted where portable gas cannot stand.

Design move. Where gas is on site and the area is open, a fixed gas supply (natural gas) to a listed appliance avoids cylinders; under awnings and near exits, specify electric. Check the permit and fire-code checklist first.

Bromic project. Rare Society, San Clemente: Platinum Electric heaters on hardwired switches heat the steakhouse's semi-enclosed patios.

Fire codes are adopted and amended locally. Confirm with your local fire marshal and authority having jurisdiction, and use a licensed electrician or gas fitter.

07 · Electrification reaches the terrace



> *New buildings in New York City may not burn any fuel that emits **25 kg or more of CO2 per million Btu**; the law applies to new construction only, phased in from low-rise buildings, with exceptions that include commercial kitchens.[10] Source: NYC Department of Buildings, Local Law 154 of 2021.*

> *New York State's All-Electric Buildings Act follows for new buildings statewide, starting with buildings of seven stories or fewer.[11]*

What it means for an operator

- New hotels, mixed-use and multifamily projects are being designed without gas.
- A kitchen exception does not cover the terrace by default.
- Whether a law reaches outdoor heaters is a local question; ask before you specify.

Bromic insight. Specifying electric outdoor heat at design stage keeps a terrace consistent with an all-electric building, with no gas line to the roof.

Design move. Rough in dedicated circuits and control wiring for the terrace in the first electrical plan, not at fit-out.

Bromic project. The Industrie, Albany: an all-electric building chose Eclipse portable heaters for its roof deck in place of gas fire tables.

Confirm requirements with your local building department and a licensed electrician.

08 · Guests come for the occasion

> ***84%** of restaurant customers say going out with family or friends is a chance to socialize and a better use of leisure time; **76%** would likely attend food tasting events at a restaurant.*[2]
> *Source: National Restaurant Association, State of the Restaurant Industry 2026.*

What it means for an operator

- Events, tastings and private dinners are traffic, and terraces host them well.
- An event booked months ahead cannot depend on the evening being mild.
- Heat and light set the mood as much as the menu.

Bromic insight. Heat that is also light, such as Eclipse with dimmable rim lighting, lets one fixture set the scene and the temperature.[15]

Design move. Treat the terrace as a bookable room: heat it in zones that match private-hire sections, each on its own Affinity controller and wall switch.

Bromic project. Pink Hill Hotel, Australia: a pub and live-music venue mixes Eclipse and Tungsten Electric heaters, with Eclipse Dimmer Controller presets.

Open pavilion set for an event with ceiling heaters

09 · Hotels make outdoor space earn



> *Hotel guest spending is projected at nearly **$805 billion** in 2026, up **1.7%**; gross operating profit per available room remains about **90%** of 2019 levels, mainly because of rising operating costs.[12] Source: American Hotel & Lodging Association, State of the Industry 2026.*

What it means for an operator

- Room revenue is growing slowly; profit is under pressure from costs.
- Rooftops, pool decks and terraces can sell food and beverage after dark.
- Domestic leisure is the largest part of US travel, and leisure guests linger outside.[12]

Bromic insight. A heated rooftop bar or pool cabana turns square footage into evening revenue without adding a room.

Design move. Give guests the control where it suits the space, as in a cabana, and keep shared terraces on scheduled zones.

Bromic projects. Stella's Wine Bar, Post Oak Hotel, Houston: Eclipse pendants and Platinum Electric heaters on dimmers, from a Bromic 2D heat plan. Ambiente Sedona: Eclipse Freestanding and Tungsten Electric heaters planned by Bromic's design team.

10 · Heat disappears into the architecture

> *Bromic defines a space as outdoor when at least **30%** of its perimeter is permanently open; short-wave heat is about **90%** radiant and warms instantly, long-wave about 40% and the most wind-sensitive.*[14] *Source: Bromic Heating, Planning Guide US v1.2, 2021.*

What it means for an operator

- Architects want heat that is felt, not seen.
- Rooftops and exposed terraces need the right wavelength, not more units.
- Recessed and pendant heat frees floor space for seats.

Bromic insight. Designed from the start, not added later: recessed, ceiling or wall-mounted Platinum and Tungsten Smart-Heat Electric heaters, each with its Affinity controls, sit in the soffit rather than the floor plan.

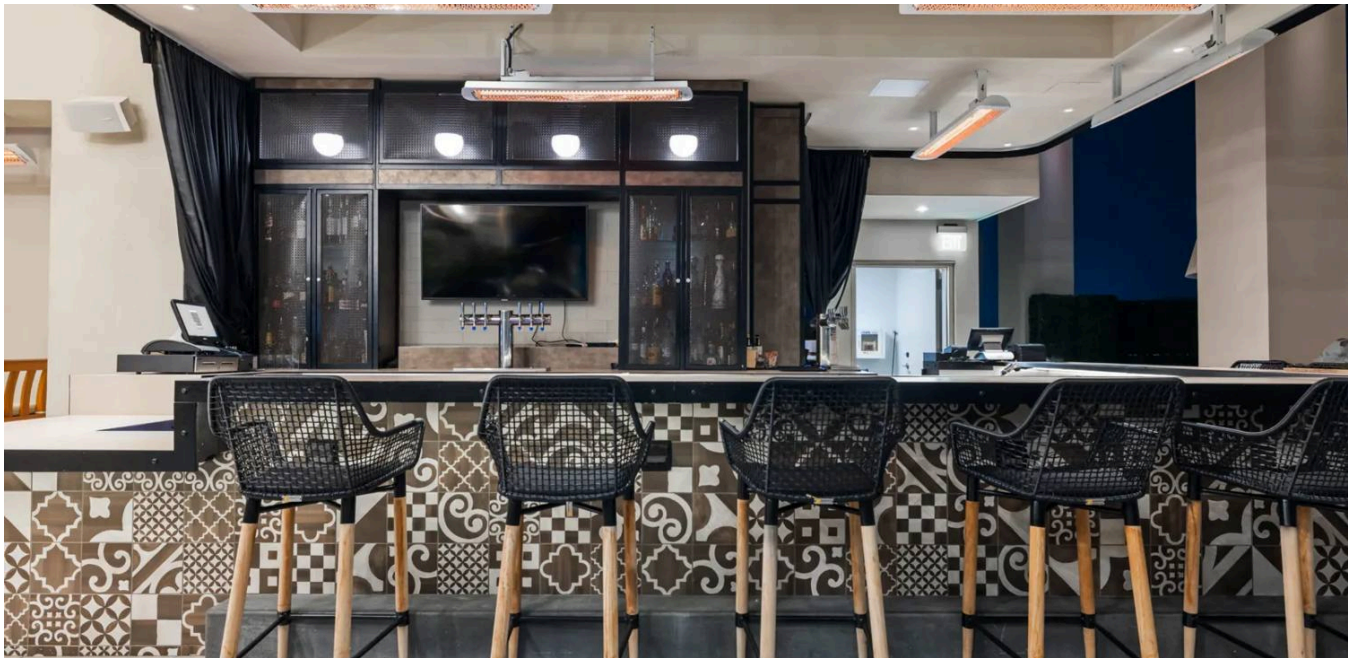
Design move. Bring heat into the reflected ceiling plan at schematic design. Ask Bromic's design service for a heat plan before the soffit is set.

Bromic projects. Christopher's at Wrigley Mansion, Phoenix: architect Wendell Burnette chose Eclipse Freestanding heaters so the restaurant could add a patio without spoiling the historic design. Hive and Honey, Irvine: wind and window-washing rigs ruled out gas and perimeter mounts on a high rooftop, so Bromic combined Eclipse portables with hardwired Tungsten Electric heaters.



Urban roof terrace with a recessed heater in a timber soffit

Key takeaways



- Treat the terrace as revenue: on-premises is where operators say they win.[2]
- Guests want the outside table; comfort decides whether they stay.[3]

- Energy cost is the reason to zone and schedule, through compatible Affinity Smart-Heat Controls.[2]
- Outdoor dining is licensed and permanent in major cities; design to the licence.[5]
- Propane faces bans and clearances; electric radiant heat removes fuel handling.[7]
- New buildings are going all-electric; plan terrace circuits in the first drawings.[10]

This report summarises public rules for orientation only. It is not legal or code advice. Confirm every requirement with your local authority having jurisdiction and a licensed electrician or gas fitter.

Find out what your empty seats are worth: get your ROI assessment.

[1]: National Restaurant Association, operator survey, September 2021. [2]: National Restaurant Association, State of the Restaurant Industry 2026. [3]: OpenTable, US consumer survey (Walr), April 2025. [4]: OpenTable, Canada diner data, March 2025 – February 2026. [5]: City of New York, Office of the Mayor, 1 April 2025. [6]: UK Government, Pavement licences: guidance, 2024. [7]: City of New York, Emergency Executive Order No. 200, 2021. [8]: City of Gresham, Oregon, local adoption of IFC 605.5, 2021. [9]: NYC Department of Buildings, Buildings Bulletin 2024-005. [10]: NYC Department of Buildings, Local Law 154 of 2021 presentation, 2023. [11]: Urban Green Council, 2025 (secondary; to be verified against the statute). [12]: American Hotel & Lodging Association, State of the Industry 2026. [13]: U.S. Energy Information Administration, Monthly Energy Review, 2026. [14]: Bromic Heating, Planning Guide US v1.2, 2021. [15]: Bromic Heating, Lookbook 2026.

NEXT STEP

Get your ROI assessment



Sources

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9. **NYC Department of Buildings**, Buildings Bulletin 2024-005 (outdoor dining under DOT's Dining Out NYC) (2024). https://www.nyc.gov/assets/buildings/bldgs_bulletins/bb_2024-005.pdf
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14. **Bromic Heating**, The Official Outdoor Heating Planning Guide, US v1.2 (2021)
15. **Bromic Heating**, Lookbook 2026 (2026)

Confirm every installation with your local building authority and a licensed electrician or gas fitter. Wi-Fi and app features need compatible Affinity Smart-Heat controls, sold separately. © 2026 Bromic Heating · bromic.com